Mineral Inventory data estimates that India is sitting on some 502 million tonnes of gold ore reserves, with the largest resources located in Bihar (44 per cent), followed by Rajasthan (25 per cent), Karnataka (21 per cent), and West Bengal and Andhra Pradesh (both 3 per cent).

However, these vast resources remain unexplored and domestic production remains a trickle. Geomysore director B. Karthikeyan, who is overseeing the project activities, says the commencement will hence be a significant milestone for India's gold mining sector. "Jonnagiri demonstrates the vast untapped potential of India's mineral resources and shows what can be achieved with the right policy support and commitment," says Karthikeyan, who is also the MD of Thriveni Earthmovers, a major shareholder in Geomysore, along with Lloyds Metals Ltd.

Takeaways

- **Jonnagiri gold mine will be inaugurated in June, will raise domestic production**
- **Estimated gold reserves of 13 tonnes, big potential for expansion**
- **It will be India's second operational gold mine, after Karnataka's Hutti mines**

In 2008, the then united AP government had granted Geomysore a reconnaissance permit for gold, copper, lead, zinc and silver at Jonnagiri and Pagidirai blocks, which is part of the Eastern Dharwar Craton. A mining lease was granted in 2013, and after securing all statutory clearances, the project is now ready to transition to commercial production. The state will receive royalty according to the value of the gold extracted from the mine. The processing plant is currently handling around 1,000 tonnes per day (TPD) of gold-bearing ore. ■



WISE MOVE Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis launches the MahaChatur AI chatbot in Mumbai, Apr. 27

▶ MAHARASHTRA

When in Maharashtra, AI Speaks in Marathi

An innovative AI policy sees the state at the helm of a race to harness the technology for local jobs

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

THE WORLD AT LARGE IS STRICKEN by anxiety about what the arrival of Artificial Intelligence means for the old economy, but Indian states may be devising an ingenious workaround—one that not only maximises its potential but actually widens the technology's capacity itself. While other states have the ink still wet on their versions, Maharashtra has become the one of the first to roll a full-fledged AI policy. Its twin premises: that AI can be turned into a jobs-and-growth engine rather than just a threat to existing work, and that making the technology speak Indian languages kills two birds with one stone.

With investments of up to Rs 10,000 crore by 2031, the AI policy approved by the Devendra Fadnavis cabinet, targets the creation of around 150,000 jobs, with training for roughly 200,000 youth and professionals in AI, big data, cloud services and other emerging tech. Officials call it the next logical step for a state that's already a major software exporter and a key IT hub, aiming to put it at the front of an Indian AI market that's projected to leapfrog in size in the near future. The framework is modelled on the Centre's IndiaAI Mission, with the promise of a "clear roadmap" for businesses, startups and research institutions.

At its core, the policy tries to argue that AI will reshape rather than kill work. Ashish Shelar, the state minister for electronics, IT and AI, says the focus is not just on automating existing jobs but on creating new AI-related jobs—or, in his words, "AI enabled development of human resources".

'AAMCHI AI'

The plan fairly bristles with ideas that mix the hardware of policy with people-oriented plans. At one end, there will be an AI backbone with 2,000 GPUs, local data ecosystems and a state-level AI data exchange; a Maharashtra Centre for Advanced Training in AI (MCAT) to be set up with industry and academic participation; a central 'Maha AI Tools Hub'; a Rs 500 crore AI Startup Venture